

*ON TO CHICAGO*

I WAS SITTING AT HOME, THINKING ABOUT MR. BLOTNICK'S ADVICE, when I saw some intriguing ads on TV. These had to do with futures and options, the very short-term investments I wondered if I should pursue full time. One said, "Investor doubles money in three weeks," while another claimed "120 percent profit in two days." A third mentioned "unlimited upside potential with predetermined risk," and a fourth challenged: "Only those who dare have truly lived." Each of them ended with the phrase: "past performance is no guarantee of future results."

The trading companies mentioned in these ads were based in Chicago. I took a chance and bought a plane ticket.

Chicago is no longer the hog butcher for the world. Hasn't been since 1959, when they closed the stockyards. Pigs are already kielbasa by the time they reach Chicago. Neither is Chicago a stacker of wheat, except in the pancake houses. Lately, it's the hog future of the world, put-maker, seller of soybean straddles, and the nation's commodities-hedger: stormy, husky, brawling, city of the reverse head-and-shoulders pattern.

I got there in mid-July, and I took a room at a cheap downtown hotel. The man at the desk told me his brother was a futures trader. Friends of my wife's family who live in Chicago had umpteen relatives in commodities. On the street, almost everybody I stopped knew the location of the Mercantile Exchange, a glassy riverfront high-rise where the trading pits were located.

Reminding myself that a future is a contract to buy something later at a price agreed upon today, I headed to the Mercantile Exchange to open an account with Lind-Waldock. Maybe you've seen their ads: instant access, professional service, operators stand-